**Regentonians Benevolent Fund Policy Document**

## 1. Overview and Introduction

The Regentonians Benevolent Fund (RBF) is established to provide benevolent support to Regentonians in the UK, in times of need. This policy document outlines the purpose, eligibility criteria, disbursement guidelines, financing, and other relevant details for the RBF. It also defines the roles and responsibilities of the Benevolence Committee and provides a framework for the consistent and sustainable implementation of benevolent initiatives.

The Sierra Leone Grammar School Old Boys' Association Foundation Trust (SLGS OBA FT (UK) is a UK registered charity with the following charitable objectives:

- The advancement of education through scholarships, fee payments, teaching aids, and equipment.
- The prevention or relief of poverty.
- The advancement of health or the saving of lives.
- The provision of recreation facilities and other leisure activities, and the relief of those in need due to youth, age, ill-health, disability, financial hardship, or other disadvantages.
- To further other purposes recognized as charitable under existing and future English and Welsh law.

Under UK Trust law, members of a charitable trust are not permitted to receive direct benefits from Trust funds, particularly for bereavement and benevolent purposes, as stipulated in the governing document and bye-laws (Appendix 4). This is because the RBF is NOT intended to relieve poverty. As such, it does NOT have a UK charitable purpose.

**Appendix 4 of the governing document states:**
"The Charity's general funds shall not be used to pay for the bereavement policy set out below. Instead, a special fund of voluntary donations made by members shall be maintained by the Treasurer to be used in accordance with the policy. In the event of insufficient funds when a member is bereaved, a special appeal may be made to the general membership for additional funds.
A fully paid-up member who has maintained such membership for at least a year at the time of passing shall be entitled to the following:

- Announcement of the funeral and arrangement for the service through the group mailing list.
- A pastoral visit to his/her family by members before the funeral.
- A card and financial donation of £75 payable to the partner or next of kin.
- Attendance at the funeral by members (subject to satisfactory traveling arrangements if the funeral is outside London) in full ceremonial uniform. Upon prior arrangement, the school song will be sung at the service."

**For lapsed and inactive members who maintained some involvement with the Association before passing:**

- Details of the funeral arrangement (if the Association is notified) will be released via our global group membership email.
- Attendance at the funeral by members (subject to satisfactory traveling arrangements if the funeral is outside London) in full ceremonial uniform. Upon prior arrangement, the school song will be sung at the service.

**For other Alumni and ex-members of staff:**

- An announcement and details of the funeral arrangement (if the Association is notified) will be released via our global group membership email.

As stated, the Trust's primary objective is to raise funds to support ongoing development projects at the Sierra Leone Grammar School. Our members do not receive direct benefits from their subscriptions; instead, contributions directly impact the educational future of students in Sierra Leone.

To further support individuals in need, an **independent benevolent fund** has been established, as stated in the bye-laws. Membership in this benevolent fund is open to all, and you do not need to be a member of the charitable trust to join. Therefore, all benevolent activities towards members must be covered by separate funding arrangements.

The RBF has been established to address the benevolent requirements of the Trust, in accordance with the Trust's constitution.

While membership of our charitable trust isn't a prerequisite for joining the benevolent fund, we strongly encourage you to consider becoming a member of the Trust first. Trust membership demonstrates your commitment to our wider charitable mission and helps us continue our vital work supporting the Sierra Leone Grammar School.

The fund will only assist qualifying individuals if they come forward or the organisation is advised by family, friends, or fellow Regentonians.

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## 2. Purpose of the Benevolence Policy

The purpose of this policy is to:

- Clarify **eligibility criteria** for beneficiaries.
- Provide **guidelines for the Benevolence Committee**.
- Outline the process for **disbursing funds**.
- Define the **expectations and responsibilities** of the Benevolence Committee.
- Establish **best practices** for implementing benevolent initiatives.
- Ensure a **standard, consistent, and sustainable** approach to supporting Regentonians in times of need.

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## 3. Eligibility

### 3.1 Membership Requirements

- The Fund is open to anyone who is a **Regentonian** and meets the criteria outlined in the Fund's guidelines from time to time.
- Membership in the SLGS OBA UK is **not a prerequisite** for joining the benevolent fund.
- We strongly encourage you to consider becoming a member of the Trust first.

### 3.2 Contribution and Benefit

- Participation in the RBF is **voluntary**.
- The Fund may accept **donations** from interested parties who are not paid-up members of the SLGS OBA FT. Provided they have been issued with the Key Facts Document, stating the RBF is not a Charitable entity and it should not be mistaken such. This will mitigate the risk of the RBF being viewed as a charitable entity by members of the public. As signed copy of this document will be held on file for reference.

### 3.3 Joining Options

- When completing a new Trust membership application or renewing your Trust membership, you will be presented with the option to join the Benevolent Fund. Alternatively, you may join the Fund at any time by completing a standalone Benevolent Fund application form.
- Upon choosing to join, you will be provided with the Fund's bank account details to enable you to set up either a **monthly standing order** or make a **one-off lump sum payment**.
- **Please note that cash deposits made directly into the Fund's bank account are not permitted.**

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## 4. Disbursement of Funds

### 4.1 Bereavement Support

- Financial disbursements will be triggered by the loss of specific family members, including but not limited to: mother, father, son, daughter, husband, spouse, or partner.
- The Committee may decide to support bereavement outside of the named family members, as agreed by the board.
- Payments will be made directly to the bereaved member or, in the case of a deceased member, to the family member responsible for funeral arrangements.
- Members can decide by a simple majority vote to use funds to assist or support members of the Trust suffering from hardship, bereavement, or distress as agreed by the Committee from time to time.

#### 4.1.1 Disbursement Amounts

- **Member:** GBP 500
- **Children (Son or Daughter):** GBP 300
- **Spouse/Partner:** GBP 200
- **Parents (Mother and Father):** GBP 200

- Where two or more siblings are active members and at least one has contributed to the Fund, a maximum contribution of GBP 300 will be made to the family.

**4.1.2 Redirection of Funds**

- Recipients may choose not to receive the funds and may request that the funds be redirected to support other expenses related to the purpose of the disbursement.
- Any remaining balance must be returned to the benevolence reserve.

**4.2 Other Occasions for Benevolence**

- The Benevolent Committee may arrange visits for members who are sick or suffering from ill health.
- A get-well-soon card and relevant items (e.g., health hamper/flowers) up to GBP 50 may be provided.
- Decisions regarding sickness/ill health support will be made on a case-by-case basis.

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**5. Pastoral Care and Support**

**5.1 Funeral Announcements**

- Announcements of funerals and arrangements will be made through appropriate channels and mailing lists, with permission from the bereaved family.

**5.2 Pastoral Visits**

- If two or more siblings are members, a combined pastoral visit before the funeral will be arranged.

**5.3 Sympathy Card**

- A Regentonians-branded sympathy card will be presented to the bereaved member/family.

**5.4 Funeral Attendance**

- Members will attend funerals (subject to satisfactory travel arrangements if the funeral is outside London) in full ceremonial uniform for all Regentonians' funerals.

**5.5 Regentonian Traditions**

- Regentonian families may request that their loved ones' coffins be draped with the Regentonian flag and that the school song be sung at the service.

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**6. Financing the Benevolent Fund / Financial Sustainability and Preparedness**

**6.1 Minimum Fund Requirement / Reserve Building**

- The Fund will aim to maintain a minimum balance of **GBP 3,000** at all times to prepare for future expenses, providing long-term stability and reliability, and to build a solid reserve.

**6.2 Member Contributions**

- All signed-up members must pay a minimum of **GBP 60 per year**.
- Contributions can be made as a lump sum by **March 30th** or through monthly standing orders of **£5 per month**.
- Bank account details will be provided during new member sign-ups, renewals, or upon request.

**6.3 Membership Contribution Arrears**

- If a member fails to make the required monthly contributions for a period of three (3) consecutive months, or in the case of annual contributions, has not made payment within three (3) months following their membership anniversary date, the Fund will make reasonable efforts to contact the member to discuss the reason(s) for non-payment.
- If the member chooses to cancel their membership, they will be required to confirm this decision in writing.
- Should the member wish to continue their membership, they will be required to settle all outstanding contributions in full.
- For monthly-paying members, this means payment of the missed three (3) months' contributions. For annually-paying members, full annual payment must be made within fourteen (14) days of such agreement.
- Failure to either confirm cancellation or make the necessary payment within the stipulated time may result in the suspension or termination of membership benefits at the discretion of the Fund.

**6.4 Fundraising**

- Initial funding will come from a campaign aimed at members to establish a "Starter Fund."
- Funds may also be raised during monthly team meetings by "passing the hat around."
- Lump-sum donations can be made at any time and for any amount.

**6.5 Excess Contributions**

- If contributions exceed the amount to be disbursed, the excess will be retained in the Fund for future disbursements.
- Members making lump-sum contributions above the minimum may request specific handling of their contribution by informing the Benevolent Committee.

**6.6 Insufficient Funds**

- If the bank account balance is insufficient to cover disbursements, members will be encouraged to make one-off contributions as necessary.

**6.7 Cancellation Policy**

- You may cancel your membership of the Benevolent Fund at any time without prior notice by providing written confirmation to the Fund Management Team. Please note that upon cancellation, you will not be entitled to any refund or reimbursement of contributions already made.

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**7. Policy Review**

- A review of these guidelines will be conducted every **12 months** to ensure they reflect the latest trends and best practices.

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**8. Key Roles and Responsibilities**

- **Welfare Officers:** Oversee the welfare and support activities of the Fund.
- **Treasurer:** Manages the financial aspects of the Fund.
- **Member Management:** Handles membership records and contributions.
- **Fund Adviser:** Provides strategic guidance on Fund operations.
- **Fund Administrators:** Manage day-to-day operations and disbursements.

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This policy document provides a comprehensive framework for the operation of The Regentonians Benevolent Fund. It ensures that the Fund is managed transparently, consistently, and sustainably, with the primary goal of supporting Regentonians in times of need.

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Last Reviewed:
Accepted by the Committee of the Regentonians Benevolent Fund on: